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Quality without Distinction: Kierkegaard, Ranciere, and Egalitarianism

The rallying cry for the French Revolution was the motto, “Liberty, Equality and Fraternity”. Perhaps most controversial for our age has been the second term of the triad: “equality”. Evoking images of the Bolshevik revolution, the value of egalitarianism has dropped out of the language of the left instead being replaced by the “empty politics”¹ (Zizek) of identity, oppression and resentment. Equality, however, was an option that could provide a positive ground for a leftist project. Similarly, another term has emerged in the aftermath of the Enlightenment as an organizing principle of the left: namely, “difference”. Difference can simultaneously be a call for a much more radical restructuring of society (e.g. Foucault’s expungement of the terms madness)², etc., but it can also be used as a support for the current sociopolitical order of liberalism (which is difference by violence; i.e., not difference at all) perpetuated by a tepid ethic of “arrogant tolerance”³ (Kant). However, another option may be available: namely, to think egalitarianism and difference in the same term—this is perhaps what

¹ Slavoj Zizek, *In Defense of Lost Causes*.

² Michel Foucault, *Madness and Civilization*.

³ Immanuel Kant, *What is Enlightenment?*

is most valuable about Kierkegaard's philosophy. That is, Kierkegaard thinks the individual in her singularity, different from every other individual, and yet equally an object of God's love and hence deserving of neighborly love as much as every other individual. This capacity to think of different individuals' qualities without distinction or hierarchical organization is both Kierkegaard's critique of all secular polities as well as his positive ground for a new *nomos* or hope through which a leftist ethic can be revitalized. In this paper, it will be argued that Kierkegaard's deconstruction of secular polity in favor of neighborly love necessarily leads us to posit a classless, stateless society grounded on the presumption of radical equality as explained by Jacques Ranciere. This reading of Kierkegaard not only concretizes his thought and resists accusations of subjectivism (Adorno) but also produces a positive vision for the left beyond empty critique. This can be further situated by examining a text by Jacques Ranciere entitled, "The Ignorant Schoolmaster". Through this encounter, it will be shown that the cogency of the leftist project rests and falls upon a radical presumption of equality and subsequently becomes an issue for theological reflection as well.

Kierkegaard and Ranciere agree on the following proposition: repetition is the acquisition of a difference that affirms no distinction other than its own differentiating power. This suggestive sentence will take a lot of work to unpack. The key terms here are the following: repetition, acquisition (learning), difference, affirmation, distinction, and differentiation. These six points can also be thought of as the six touchpoints where Kierkegaard and Ranciere's thought meet and through which the power of repetition as difference can also be thought. Another thinker who would ascent to this proposition is Gilles Deleuze. One major thesis of "Difference and Repetition" is that repetition is not generality and that, through this

reconceptualization of repetition without a concept, one can approach the goal of a “philosophy of the future” namely, a “thought without image”. This thought without image is integral to thinking Ranciere’s equality of intelligence between all individuals, as well as my own thesis of a quality without distinction.

Proposition 1—“Religion is to Represent Moral Duty as Divine Command”

The critique of representation is crucial for Kant’s project. This is because without an analysis of reason’s immanent power of positing Ideas for the imagination to schematize, we would become lost in the paralogisms of pure reason, taking the apparitions of reason as if they were determinable through the categories which render our empirical intuitions sensible. In other words, Kant’s philosophy of mind is composed of the following elements: the forms of intuition, the categories of the understanding, the ideas of reasoning, and the schematizations of the imagination. The forms of intuition (whether inner or outer) are ready-made to receive sense-data from the world—the imagination then borrows concepts from the categories in order to schematize them into representations of the world. However, Kant notes in the first *Critique* that reason strives for the unconditioned and hence seeks to posit the world, self and God as real objects in the world. However, there is no intuition of the world, self or God as such because these are merely regulative Ideas which explain the sensibility of phenomena to our moral agency. This means that the imagination is schematizing the Ideas of Reason through the categories, giving determinacy (positing as existing in space-time, as being causally efficient, etc.) without intuitions which correspond to them—hence, Kant says that these are transcendental illusions. As Deleuze points out, “illusion is not error” (D+R).⁴ Error would be the

⁴ Gilles Deleuze, *Difference and Repetition*.

function of mind when it accounts for facts incorrectly, as a young student might make when he states that $2+2=5$. Illusion, on the other hand, confers that there is a *real* determinacy being given to the objects (world, self, God) but that this determinacy is illusory because, rather than realizing that they are regulative ideas that govern the power of reason, they are taken for objects despite the fact that there are no corresponding intuitions which can be offered as the ground for their determinacy. They are apparitions produced by reason's immanent power, alone, and not through reason's encounter with a force in the world which its power must be applied to.

This Kantian schema is what Climacus is burrowing when he makes the distinction between the lunatic and the knight of faith at the beginning of "Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments". He distinguishes the two by stating the former (lunatic) puts the infinite passion of inwardness onto something finite, as opposed to the knight of faith who puts the infinite passion of inwardness onto something infinite (namely, God). The language of "inwardness" roughly corresponds to either the transcendental faculties as elaborated by Kant, or to inner intuition, which is a product of the categories as they provide determinacy to the subject's experience or intuition of themselves. Hence, to put "the infinite passion of the inward" on finite things is a reversal of the problem of transcendental illusion: namely that one has created apparitions or determinate objects which correspond to concepts (the objectivity of the statement, "Boom! The Earth is Round!") but are not representative of the intuition that the asylum escapee is trying to express: "I am not crazy". This intuition, or proposition, is therefore not taken up because, as Climacus distinguishes, despite its objective form (i.e., the "what" of what is said) it is incoherent in its subjective form (i.e., the "how" of what is said) and hence betrays the fact that the escapee lacks the shared norms of communicability that is common to

the citizens of Denmark. In other words, it corresponds to what Kant discusses in the third *Critique* regarding the requisite “sociability” which allows for the proper exercise of the transcendental faculties, and hence the requisite for realizing one’s own status as a member of a universal “Kingdom of Ends”.⁵

Climacus states, regarding lunacy and truth, “In a solely subjective definition of truth, lunacy and truth are ultimately indistinguishable, because they may both have inwardness” (194). He elaborates in the footnote when he states the following:

“Even this is not true, however, because madness never has the inwardness of infinity. Its fixed idea is a kind of objective something, and the contradiction of madness lies in wanting to embrace it with passion. The decisive factor in madness is thus not the subjective, but the little finitude that becomes fixed, something the infinite can never become” (194).

This footnote elucidates on several factors. Let us recall Climacus’ preceeding definition of objective and subjective when he states that, “[t]o objective reflection, truth becomes something objective, an object, and the point is to disregard the subject. To subjective reflection, truth becomes appropriation, inwardness, subjectivity, and the point is to immerse oneself, existing, in subjectivity” (192). The structure here, therefore, is that, in objective reflection, the priority is on the object—namely, that it is communicable in its objectivity independent of the subject who is beholding the object whereas, for subjective reflection, the priority is less on the object but rather on the capacity for inwardness or subjectivity to be able to appropriate something and hence not to leave it abject. In other words, truth has two components—the first being a universal determinacy independent of subjects (objective reflection) and second being an

⁵ Immanuel Kant, *Critique of the Power of Judgment*, 176.

appropriability appropriate to inward reflection (subjective reflection). Subsequently, after the footnote describing the difference between lunacy and truth, Climacus gives us the account of a man who has escaped an asylum and, having found his way to an adjacent town, tries to convince others of his sanity by attaching a ball to his tailcoat and uttering, “Boom! The Earth is round!” every time the attached ball strikes his rear (195). Climacus’ argument, roughly, is that the escapee is making the mistake of confusing truth-as-such with truth as it is objectively reflected—or, as Climacus states elsewhere, with the “what” of the proposition and not the “how”. While the propositional content of his statement is true, independent of any *particular* subject who takes up the proposition, the lunacy becomes clear because of the manner in which it is said (without provocation, irrelevant to any subject-position, without being hailed upon, to use a psychoanalytic term, as a *subject of enunciation*).⁶

Let us examine the footnote more closely now. Climacus states that the elements which betray the failure of the lunatic’s understanding of subjective reflection are 1.) that madness lacks the “inwardness of infinity” and instead has an inwardness of finitude; 2.) that it has a “fixity” upon an “objective something” which it “embraces with passion”—hence he concludes that, despite understanding objective reflection, the “decisive factor” is not merely subjective reflection but that subjective reflection tries to appropriate a truth on which a finite thing is embraced with the inwardness properly belonging to the infinite and hence fixes itself in contradiction. Whereas what is most proper to subjective reflection is the infinite (perhaps conjecturally named as world, self, and God), these nevertheless cannot become fixed in finite

⁶ Jacques Lacan, *Four Fundamental Concepts*. Lacan uses the term to distinguish between the subject who is speaking (the subject of the statement), and the subject of enunciation (the subject of the unconscious which emerges through transference).

reflection but, though located within it as what is most proper to subjective reflection, exceed the very possibility of any finite deduction.

This is an odd rendering of the passage of the escapee and his belief in his own capacity for objective reflection and how it betrays his lunacy. One would suspect that Climacus would only have to rely on the spontaneity and non-sociability of this man's response but, instead, it is in the manner in which the determinacy of the object is given within the exercise of one's transcendental faculties—namely, that the escapee has staked his life on his ability to repeat an innocuous (finite, nonimportant) claim as if it were infinite.

It will be helpful to recall the structure of Kant's exercise of the transcendental faculties of the mind. Kant believes that we give determinacy to objects through the application of concepts from the categories of the understanding. When the understanding is applied appropriately, namely, to the forms of intuitions, then what is rendered is the perception of a determinate object. However, when the understanding exercises its transcendental capacity on the ideas of reason, we run into the problems of the paralogisms where what is rendered is understanding of objects not capable of being intuited within space and time (like world as a totality, the apperceptive self, or a sovereign God) and hence produce a contradiction. Hence, when reason reflects on its own synthesizing activity, it is then capable of recognizing its proper limits and hence not confusing apparitions of its own illegitimate usage with sensations produced by its own power.

Climacus is clearly translating, for his own purposes, elements of the Kantian schema. The notion of "objectively reflected" maps well onto Kant's categories of the understanding—and the "subjectively reflected" maps well onto the Ideas of Reason. However, some key

differences emerge as well because the understanding/reason divide is not clearly objective/subjective. To put it another way, Kant and Climacus have opposite problems. For Kant, the problem of dogmatism emerges when we give the Ideas of Reason (world, self and God) determinacy through the categories of the understanding, thus treating them as empirical phenomena (despite the fact that they do not correspond to any possible intuition but rather are the conditions of possibility for intuitions). Climacus' definition of madness, however, is *not* the problem of the illegitimate use of the faculties—instead, it is that the merely empirical phenomena (Boom! The Earth is round!) is taken up as if they were Ideas of Reason (namely, universally communicable conditions of reason or rationality) when, in actuality, it is merely a single example of an empirical proposition and not, as the escapee believes, the legitimating ground of empirical propositions as such.

Hence the unconvincing element in the escapee is the incommunicability of his concepts. This incommunicability stems from his inability to represent the world *in the right way*. It is not that the representation failed to account for the objective content of reality properly but lacked its appropriate inward ground. The role of representation also arises for Kant when he turns to rational theology: “Religion is (subjectively considered) the recognition of all our duties as divine commands.”⁷ Kant goes on to distinguish between two forms of religion—revealed and natural religion, as well as four forms of religionists—rationalist, naturalist, pure rationalist, and supernaturalist.⁸ What distinguishes these four categories are whether the religionist believes that revelation is required or if natural religion is sufficient. The rationalist requires only natural

⁷ Immanuel Kant, *Religion within the Boundaries of Mere Reason*, 153.

⁸ *Ibid.*, 154.

religion; the naturalist rejects supernatural revelation; the pure rationalist allows for supernatural revelation but recognizes that it is not necessarily for religion; the supernaturalist requires revelation for religion. He subsequently distinguishes between this prior schemata as one grounded “to its first origin and inner possibility” and offers another schemata grounded in the capability of its “external communication” which renders religion into one of two types: natural religion (one which all humans can be convinced of) or learned religion (which requires education to be inculcated within).⁹ The asylum escapee has learned to perform the correct statements—objectively considered, his statement is true. But in regards to its inner possibility, he has nevertheless failed to comprehend the social command. If religion is to represent moral duty as divine command, then the escapee is incapable of representation. But if he is incapable of representation, then natural religion is not capable of being universally applicable. Kant states, “But every religion in part at least, even a revealed religion, must also contain certain principles of natural religion.”¹⁰ Hence there seems to be a paradox—though the escapee is considered socially incommunicable, religion requires that he be considered as capable of receiving divine command—namely, that he be capable of positing as his inner possibility natural religion. If religion is the representation of moral duty as divine command, then it seems to follow that revealed religion must have an appropriate form of pedagogy to inculcate him into learned religion since, otherwise, it would threaten the very solvency of that religion’s universal applicability—since, to be universally applicable requires that each individual be able to take it up as their ground *without distinction*.

⁹ Ibid.

¹⁰ Ibid., 155.

Proposition 2—Neighborly love, the duty to love one’s neighbor, is the duty to *represent* the world such that moral duty becomes spontaneous activity

In proposition 1, we’ve shown that the purpose of Kierkegaard’s pseudonyms is to demonstrate the power of representation and how the maxims by which we live produce, ontologically, differentiated ways of engaging one’s internal intensities with the forces in the world (Deleuze). Hence, for example, the aesthete and Judge Williams, not only differ in terms of their justification for life, conceptually, but the disclosure or appearance of their respective worlds (Heidegger) and their capacity to feel satisfaction (Lacan). Proposition 2, therefore, is that the duty towards neighborly love involves the duty to represent the world in such a way that moral duty becomes spontaneous activity—for example, Kierkegaard states in works of love that to give a poor man food without considering it a feast is to still consider him as a poor man and not a neighbor (that is, without distinction) and hence fails to achieve the duty towards neighborly love.¹¹ Hence, representation is not merely a passive activity of a receptive transcendental subject but an active capacity of a law-legislating subject (Kant). The same force encounters both the aesthete and Judge Williams, yet their spontaneous affect towards it is differentiated—that is, their *desire* is different (Kant) and hence our duty is not merely towards what we do but also what we most deeply desire (Zizek).

Ranciere makes the distinction between intelligence and will. He does this by asking us to imagine two students—one produces a superior paper while one produces an inferior paper. What was determinant of the result? What produced the differences between the two students? The first answer we might give us that the student with the superior paper had a superior intellect

¹¹ Soren Kierkegaard, *Works of Love*, 92.

and the student with an inferior paper had an inferior intellect. However, the ground for this belief is merely an empiricism in effects which it traces back into the cause—we do not see a superior and inferior intellect; only a superior and inferior paper. As Ranciere states, “One must show the cause of the inequality, at the risk of burrowing it from the protuberants, or be reduced to merely stating a tautology.”¹² So what else could account for the differences between the students? It could have been a superior and inferior application of the students’ capacities—the student with the superior paper *tried harder* or applied their will more effectively to the task at hand. This then begs the question—what produces the differences in will? He states, “We know why young children so similar an intelligence to exploring their world and learning their language...” but soon after, “Circumstances become diverse, and he develops the intellectual capacities as those circumstances demand.”¹³ What Ranciere concludes, then, is that in order to make representable to us the equal capacity for every student to learn, we have to *a priori* or tautologically presuppose the presumption of equality—namely, that *all* individuals have equal intellect because an individual is ultimately a will served by intelligence. This will can then direct their intelligence, their capacities, their body with its habits and quirks, towards the development of particular tasks. Inasfar as they continue to apply the will, they will unfold out of themselves the production of new thoughts and ideas—the task of the teacher, then, is to supply the deficiencies of the will through arbitrary deadlines in order to stir the intelligence towards a reorganization of its capacities. He states, “The arbitrariness of the will—revolutionary and imperial—has now taken over the promised land of well-made languages that yesterday’s reason

¹² Jacques Ranciere, *The Ignorant Schoolmaster*, 49.

¹³ *Ibid.*, 51.

promised.”¹⁴ Recounting the failure of the imperial court’s attempts to produce a thoroughly rational language, Ranciere notes that all language is arbitrary because all language—all knowledge, even, is tautological. Hence, the differences in the quality of work comes from differences in how the will has organized one’s capacities, and subsequently how one’s capacities are received into the broader society which comes to recognize and validate its significance—“Will is the power to be moved, to act by its *own* movement, before being an instance of choice.”¹⁵

To apply this to Kierkegaard’s terminology, what Ranciere has done is to see each student without distinction—they all have the equal ability to learn. This is a matter of representation, which is a matter of the will. The will of the emancipated teacher is to represent all students as having equal ability to learn, regardless of current capacities, and regardless of the teacher’s capacity (hence the teacher who teaches what he doesn’t know). In return, he will stir the will of the students to represent the object of their study different, to experiment with the intensities this produces on their bodies, and to move from enfolded habits of study, incorporating contingent encounters into the world, and learn to organize their will in such a way that they can produce, out of their own intelligence, something they were incapable of before. All of this requires of the pedagogue that they put away the distinction between higher and lower intelligences, just as Kierkegaard encourages us to put away distinctions such as erotic love and friendship in order to perform our duty towards neighborly love.

¹⁴ Ibid., 54.

¹⁵ Ibid.

The reference to the “instance of choice” has two corollaries in Kierkegaard. Firstly, it is brought up by Climacus when he discusses Socrates. Climacus states, “... the teacher stands in a reciprocal relation, inasmuch as life and its situations are the occasion for him to become a teacher and he in turn the occasion for others to learn something.”¹⁶ Juxtaposed to this is the moment which “emerges precisely in the relation of the eternal resolution to the unequal occasion” and, failing this, “we return to the Socratic.”¹⁷

Secondly, the “instance of choice” has a corollary in another pseudonym—namely, Judge Williams. He scolds A stating, “it is by no means a matter of indifference how one uses one’s youth, that one has a choice, a real either/or”.¹⁸ For the Judge, there is no indifference choice and, after chastising A some more, states “if one does not choose absolutely, one chooses for that moment only and can, for that reason, choose something else the next instant”.¹⁹ Judge Williams does not recognize that momentary choice (that is, the aesthetic choice—which is the choice of representing to oneself the choice of one’s own representation) as attaining the value of the moment of decisive significance—that is, the either/or between good or evil.

But for Ranciere, as for Kierkegaard, and for Kant, the choice to represent to oneself one’s duty is precisely the moment when one gain’s their absolute significance; namely, their realize that the ground of the moral law is in their own status as persons—persons culpable of living their own lives, and of recognizing in themselves as well as others the feature of the

¹⁶ Soren Kierkegaard, *Philosophical Fragments*, 23.

¹⁷ *Ibid.*, 24-25.

¹⁸ Soren Kierkegaard, *Either/Or*, 481.

¹⁹ *Ibid.*, 485.

neighborly. And it is only on the basis of this representation that one can direct one's will towards an action. Will has to be moved on its own power before the instance of choice even occurs, as Ranciere reminds us.

Hence, the role of representation is to produce spontaneous activity. Seen phenomenally, then we can say that a person did "x, y or z" because they had the corresponding representation. However, seen noumenally, then we see that we are responsible for the representations we give ourselves and hence that the freedom of the will overcomes the efficient causality of the world in order to do something different (and hence why moral accountability is the belief that one could and even should have done something differently). Masochistic effort is not morality because if one is masochistic towards one's duty, then one has failed to desire their duty—instead, they desire the pleasure that accompanies the pain through the exertion of their own effort (Lacan). Instead, if one represents the world in accordance with their duty, they will neither desire the pain of masochism nor require the pleasure of preferential love—they will be able to see each individual clearly; i.e., to see them as God sees them and hence to be able to love them each in their quality (as they are) without distinction—which is how God loves us.

Nevertheless, Kierkegaard seems to suggest that the duty towards neighborly love does not require that we disavow, abandon, or renounce our preferential loves. However, the important thing is that preferential loves are contingent while the duty to love is universal and hence why "death cannot deprive you of your neighbor".²⁰.

Proposition 3—Neighborly love means bracketing particular love in favor of the universal

²⁰ Ibid., 76-77.

In *Fear and Trembling*, Johannes De Silentio states, “When I think of Abraham, I am virtually annihilated”²¹ and continues further, “If one hasn’t the courage to think this thought through, to say that Abraham was a murderer, then surely it is better to acquire that courage than to waste time on undeserved speeches in his praise.”²² What makes him so terrifying is precisely that he cannot render his understanding of God’s command communicable—he also eschews the traditional categories of life and death and, nevertheless insists, that he will receive Isaac back, not in the next life but in this life—that is, this same life that he is committed to sacrificing him within, as well. De Silentio continues, “This is what is terrible. Anyone who doesn’t see this can always be quite certain he is no knight of faith: but anyone who does see it will not deny that the step of even the most tried tragic hero goes like a dance compared with the slow and creeping progress of the knight of faith”.²³

In this passage, Kierkegaard is commenting on the constitutive contradiction of the knight of faith—namely, that he has an absolute relation to universal which requires him to surrender himself to the particular against the universal—that is, he has to prove that he loves God by killing that which he loves and was given to him by God’s love, namely Isaac, which is a hateful act, for the sake of God’s love. It is madness and incomprehensible, but it is this kind of limit-experience which constitutes faith. For the tragic hero, though his fate is difficult and, well, tragic, it is nevertheless clear in its meaning and *telos* because it is comprehensible; the particular is that for which the universal is subsumed under and hence its voluntary submission to the

²¹ Søren Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling*.

²² *Ibid.*, 60.

²³ *Ibid.*, 105.

universal is considered heroic by everyone—it is comprehensible. Abraham is not comprehensible—faith is not communicable between its adherents, and hence why Kierkegaard says earlier, “Either the single individual becomes a knight of faith himself by putting on the paradox, or he never becomes one. Partnership in these regions is quite unthinkable” (99). By its very nature, faith is something which inhibits the possibility of there being a community since, by definition, a community is a set of particulars subsumed under the universal.

Kierkegaard defines this paradox by stating that, “[f]aith, on the contrary, is this paradox, that interiority is higher than exteriority, or to recall again an expression we use above, that the odd number is higher than the even” (97). These abstract terms are, presumably, a reference to Hegel wherein the development of Spirit emerges when it recognizes itself as its own concept and hence interior to itself, but recognizes within its own self-relation the need to express its terms universally (Hegel’s distinction between a particular object and the enunciation of said object through universal designators such as “this” or “that”). Hence, Spirit, which is its own immediacy, comes into internal contradiction, which it must express in exteriority culminating in the exterior (or universal’s) subsuming of the interior (or particular). However, what Kierkegaard is pointing out is that Abraham is something different because Abraham not only has this particular relationship to the universal (namely, that he loves his son Isaac for the sake of God who gave Isaac to him) but that he now also kill this son whom he loves (which is hatred), violating the universal (since it is murder), for the sake of the Absolute. Hence the absurdity.

The communicability of this act is therefore impossible. This concept is even difficult to enunciate for Johannes De Silentio (or for myself, for that matter) and hence the role that repetition has to play—almost obsessively returning to the same problematic—in order to be able

to resolve an irresolvable problem (not unlike the neurotic's relationship to the Real which simultaneously constitutes and frustrates one's desire).

Kierkegaard attempts yet another explanation of the paradox in a footnote on 105, distinguishing between Agamemnon, an example of a tragic hero, and Abraham, *the* example of the knight of faith. Tragic heroes must “assure[] [them]sel[ves] that the ethical obligation... is totally present in him by virtue of the fact that he transforms it into a desire” (105). Hence there is no contradiction between one's moral duty and desire for happiness (the Kantian problem which requires invocation of a kingdom of Ends)—the tragic hero has to renounce personal happiness.

But Abraham is not the tragic hero—instead, Abraham is the one who practices neighborly love. As Kierkegaard states, “Alas, Christianity teaches that this is mockery of God. —The same holds true of friendship as of erotic love, insofar as this also is based on favouritism”.²⁴ Abraham takes his beloved son and does not disavow his father relation to him. Nevertheless, he represents this relation to himself differently—namely, as neighborly love. In seeing Isaac this way, he sees him as God does and hence puts his faith on the infinite; outwardly, Abraham is left without communicability in his act but inwardly, he cannot express why but knows that God is with him. Johanna De Silentio states, “Faith is the highest passion in a human being. Many in every generation may not come that far, but none comes further.”²⁵ What Abraham learned in loving Isaac not as his son but as his neighbor is that *death cannot deprive you of your neighbor*.

²⁴ Søren Kierkegaard, *Works of Love*, 36.

²⁵ Søren Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling*, 146.

Proposition 4—Universality is redefined not as (hierarchical) ethical duty but as egalitarianism

Abraham learned, that there was no distinction between Isaac, his son, and Isaac his neighbor—and he obeyed the duty to love his neighbor. It is this reformulation of representation, or this capacity for re-representing, that synchs together the aesthetic with the religious—while the ethical waits for the moment of decisive significance, the former two recognize in representation a power of modulating intensities independent of communicability and, indeed, prior to all forms of communicability. Representation no longer becomes about representing a world out there which is universally available through the categories—instead, it is through the power of representation that communication is rendered possible.

Kierkegaard announces the purpose of his pseudonym, Climacus, when he states in an appendix, “Now he despairs, his life is waste, his youth is spent in these deliberations. Life has not acquired any meaning for him, and all this is a fault of philosophy” (xiii). This is a familiar situation for many philosophy students. Climacus is close to the precipice of faith and yet, despite his endless rumination and reasoning, cannot pass over the event horizon of doubt and into faith. Having taken doubt as a starting point, he cannot “go further” and finds that this experience is isomorphic with that of the faith—many speculative philosophers have thought they have gone further than Cartesian doubt and many contemporary Christians have thought they have gone further than Abraham. This is a theme picked up from Johannes De Silentio who is rendered incommunicable regarding Abraham because the lack of mediation through the universal bypasses any comprehension of Abraham through ethical and aesthetic categories—there is no either/or in faith, in other words. This is a theme that Climacus will pick up again in

Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments when he writes the chapter “A Review in Danish Literature”.

Before moving further, however, it will be helpful to work through the fragmentary nature of the reflection of *Philosophical Fragments*. Climacus gives us a statement of intent in chapter 3 when he states, “This, then, is the ultimate paradox of thought: to want to discover something that thought itself cannot think” (37). One sees echoes here of the Kantian formula from the *Critique of Pure Reason* where he states that, “Reason strives for the unconditioned”.²⁶ Throughout Climacus work, we see a slight modification or “reduplication” of Kantian themes but their differentiation from the Kantian formulations will give us a clue as to how to interpret them.

Climacus makes a comment regarding the attempt to make an apology for the existence of God asking, “But what is this unknown against which the understanding in its paradoxical passion collides and which even disturbs man and his self-knowledge” (39). This knots together the notions of understanding, paradox, passion, and man’s self-reflexive capacity to think the conditions of possibility of their own thought. If God does not exist, it would be “impossible to demonstrate it” but if God does, then the attempt to demonstrate it would be “foolishness... since I, in the very moment the demonstration commences, would presuppose it not as doubtful” and hence would undermine the meaning of faith. Faith cannot be apologized for precisely because it is the ultimate barrier between one community, namely the secular, unbelieving world, and the community constituted by the relationship between believers.

²⁶ Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*.

Climacus picks up the theme of sociability when he states, “The court of law does not demonstrate that a criminal exists but that the accused, who does indeed exist, is a criminal” (40). The determinacy of the criminal is not contained in the object itself but rather in the judgment that the court renders regarding the object, i.e., the real existing human individual. In other words, there are categories applied regarding the relationship the individual has to the universal that renders him either a criminal or a citizen. Criminality and citizenship are not properties of an existing individual but the individual rendered as an object of the court’s judgment.

Conclusion

In conclusion, we have explored four different propositions starting from the nature of representation and exploring its various metamorphoses throughout the pseudonyms and its implications on the nature of communicability, sociability, and individual identity, as well as questioned the appropriate ground of education, and the appropriate ground of distinctions among unique individuals.

If the lunatic resembles the knight of faith, then the difference between the two is the qualification of a distinction—namely, the distinction between the fixity of one’s inward passion fixed upon the finite versus the fixity of one’s inward passion on the infinite. But we are commanded to love our neighbor as ourselves—which is to say, to love without distinction. Hence, the categories rework the notion of communicability in Kant—no longer is it merely *a priori* and universal standards which are the requisite for sensible phenomena but, for Climacus, the legitimacy of their exercise is precisely that they have communicability without distinction. This slight differentiation, which turns in the inward into the outward, unravels the knot of

passion, reason and communicability, delving into the depths of unreason and discovering love as the only thing which deserves our attention (that is, Kierkegaard discovers it through the transition from Climacus and into Works of Love). Hence, we should read “Works of Love” and Kierkegaard’s corpus as a whole not only as a critique of all secular aims or projects, but of secular polities as well. In other words, a properly Kierkegaardian ethic, is one which makes no distinction between lunatic and rational agent, criminal or citizen, foreigner or neighbor, nor between the self and other—hence “you should love your neighbor as your *self*”. Kierkegaard undermines the logic of all institutions grounded in the hierarchy of peoples and posits a radically egalitarian ethic that can no longer support courts, military, police, prisons, schools, or even the parish church... all undone by the practice of neighborly love.

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